

Conversation

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Host: Good solutions to challenges McMaster students face. For the first time in over a decade, we have nine candidates running to be the next MSU president. This is a strong signal to the MSU that students feel empowered by their student union and see a path to securing leadership and making positive changes within their community. Thank you to all the candidates for throwing your hats in the ring. Above the candidates, you will see a QR code. Towards the end of the debate, we will be asking questions from students. If you have a burning question for the candidates and would like a chance to hear them respond, you can scan the QR code at any time and submit your question for consideration. With us having nine candidates, we have a lot to get through tonight, so let's just jump right in. We will first give each candidate 30 seconds to introduce themselves. Going in alphabetical order by last name, we will start with. Terry. You can go ahead.

Terry: Okay. Thank you very much. I just want to begin by saying it's such a pleasure to be here and to share the stage with eight other fantastic candidates. I think we've gotten to know each other pretty well over the last week or so. We've practically grown roots in Musk, so it's been a lot of fun. They have great platforms, and it's great to be. To be a part of such a great team of people. I think most of you guys will recognize me from Musk. I would have mentioned some of my earlier work before, but I can't believe how much time and effort me and my team have put into this campaign. So I want to thank them as well for all the work they've put into it.

Host: Thank you.

Host: Oh, wow.

Christopher Xenos: That was quick.

Host: Next we have Emily Donjong.

Emily Donjong: Hi, everybody. My name is Emily. I'm in my fourth year of the Honors Social Psychology program here, and I am running to hopefully be your next MSU president. Like Terry said, I'm sure you're familiar with all of us. You've seen our faces in Musk. But I'm extremely excited to be here tonight and look towards making our campus extremely engaging and make campus participation better and more possible for all of our students. Thank you.

Host: Thank you. You'll move now to Juliana. Jack.

JJ: Hi, folks. My name is jj. I use she her pronouns. My platform is very focused on advocacy and the people, and I'd like to take a time to acknowledge that today is a Holocaust Day of Remembrance. There's been a lot of conflict in the world. A lot of our Iranian peers are going through a lot right now, and the thing that we need to Focus on is bringing each other and coming together and protecting each other. And that is the main focus of what I want to do as MSU president.

Host: Thank you. Next we have Abdullah Masoodi.

Abdullah Masoodi: Good evening, everybody. My name is Abdullah Masoodi. I'm in my fourth year of the Biomedical Discovery and Commercialization Program. It's really refreshing to see so many people out here tonight. I remember early in my first year coming into these sort of events and seeing only a handful of people, but we've got at least 100 people sitting in front of me. More people watching from upstairs, more people from out here. And as someone who's been in this space for years, it's so meaningful to me to see people come out and show interest.

Host: Next, Olami Olaleri.

Host: Hello, everyone. My name is Olami and my fourth is here at this school. For me, it's not just running for myself, it's about running for you guys. Giving students your voice, especially when they don't know where to search their voice for. The student union here is meant to represent the student. And it's like I keep giving this analogy, it's about WI fi. You're paying for WI Fi, but necessarily you're not using a lot of the benefits that come with it. So about essentially stretching out the scope of the student union here for the students here at the university to the best way that they can possibly use services that they are paying for.

Host: Thank you. Next we have Aaron Rebelo.

Olami Olaleri: Hello, everyone. My name is Erin. I am so happy to be here in front of all of you. Also really scared. I'm shaking in my boots. But it's so great that we have this active participation. I'm in my fourth, actually fifth year of Earth and Environmental Sciences with a minor in community Engagement and Sustainability. My platform focuses on creating a comfy campus, enhancing student life, and focusing the MSU back to its roots of advocacy and solidarity.

Host: Thank you. Next we have Mariam Saleem.

Mariam Saleem: Hi, everyone, My name is Mariam, in my fourth year of the arts and science program. I am really excited to be here talking to you all tonight and also running for president. My platform is generally rooted in access, student life and advocacy. And overall, I just really want to enhance the student life and quality of life on campus, as well as uplift everyone's voices.

Host: Thank you. Next we have Colin Scott.

Emily Donjong: Hi, everyone.

Colin Scott: I'm Colin and it's great to see everyone here. I wasn't expecting to have so many candidates. Nine is as high as you've heard, like in 10 years. I really look forward to speaking with everyone and showing how I can make the MSU so much better.

Host: Thank you. And last but not least, we have Christopher Xenos.

Christopher Xenos: Hi. Pleasure to meet you all. I'm Christopher Xenos, the only first year student that was dumb enough to run. My main policy promises are that I'm going to slash bureaucracy in

the MSU government, increase accessibility in school affairs, so no more tape violations like me tackling unaffordability and cutting wasteful spending and inefficiency in MSU governance.

Host: Thank you to all the candidates. As a reminder, for anyone in the audience, either online or in person, if you'd like to ask a question, please either scan the QR code. If you're online, write your question into the chat and we will note it down for you. Audience questions will be compiled and asked during the audience questions portion of the debate. And next, we will be moving into the question period. The MSU elections committee drafted the following questions based on current student issues and candidate platform points. For this portion of the debate, we will ask a series of questions and each candidate will have 30 seconds to respond. At the end of question period, we will move into an open debate and rebuttal period. This will be the opportunity for other candidates to rebut any of the comments made by the other candidates. We will have Vidya and Jasmine sitting in the front row who will serve as our timekeepers in the debate. They will raise a yellow card when you have 15 seconds left to speak and a red card when your time is up. With that, we will get started. Our first question is as follows. As president, you have the ability to decide what projects you emphasize throughout the year. What platform point will you focus on first? And how will you ensure it creates meaningful and lasting change? We will start in the same order as the introductions. So, Terry, you may begin.

Terry: Yeah. I think the most important point that I would have to emphasize is my new student poll that I'm trying to get out. It's going to be an annual incentivized poll that's going to ask students about their concerns about advocacy at the msu, about events that we want to see on campus. It's going to kind of allow the MSU to bridge the divide between the concerns of the student body and platform them institutionally through data so that student voice becomes central to MSU goings on in the future.

Host: Thank you. Next we have Emily Tanjal.

Emily Donjong: One of the initiatives I'm proposing is a small business kickstart program that would allow students a more accessible way to get some of their small, small business ideas up and running. I think we've seen firsthand on our campus how students like Margaret, the founder of the Grind Market, I mean, I'm wearing her earrings right now, have had such meaningful impacts on our community. And I think it's important that the MSU provides more opportunities for students to propel their ideas forward and make meaningful change.

Host: Next we have Juliana.

JJ: I think the first thing I would focus on for my platform is advocacy. I think that there's a lot of issues being overlooked at this university. And yes, it would be great to get more student feedback, but. But marginalized voices have been crying out for years begging for help. We have reports that show, yes, maybe the sample sizes aren't conducive of the whole population, but how much longer are we just going to be given more platforms to share our stories before someone actually starts picking up something and doing some work? So that's what I focus on.

Host: Next we have Abdullah.

Abdullah Masoodi: Yeah, of course, a big part of my platform is investing in student culture and

finding ways to figure out how we can tie people to this campus besides just, you know, the classroom. One of the things in my student culture platform is supporting athletics. And as a student athlete, myself and I see many student athletes in the crowd right now. We love when students engage with us inside the court while we're playing outside of as well. One of the big things I want to focus on as I step in the role is advancing the idea of the student section that I wanted to build.

Host: Thank you. Next we have Alami.

Christopher Xenos: So something I want to kind of decide on, the sense of student culture is that aspect of differences that we have amongst the individuals that are in here today. I'm Nigerian myself, and if you go across this table here on the students right here, you find someone from almost every different country. What I want to develop is working with the different clubs that we have under the student union and developing a full week event on something that we can have, in a sense of Cultural Week. We're celebrating people's differences, but we're also celebrating something like food, dances, music, just a different way to experience each other's culture.

Host: Next we have Erin.

Erin: From an organizational perspective, the first thing you start on is not necessarily the most important thing. It's the thing you can get into motion first. And for me, that would be bidets, because looking at the facts and how much it would cost to start a bidet pilot project of six bidets, it would cost \$3,613 per student. And that's something I can start in motion in May and have ready before the school year. All my other points take longer and of course they'll occur throughout the year and into the coming years.

Host: Thank you. Next we have Miriam.

Emily Donjong: One of my most actionable and tangible items that I plan on starting imminently is kind of to bolster and secure the FCC and their funding and the increases that are necessary in there. One would be to expand the soup and bread initiative to Monday as well. Other than that is also to ensure that their funding is able to reach their third party donors as well as their travel budget line so they can continue to.

Host: Help the students.

Host: Thank you. Next we have Colin.

Colin Scott: I would start off by creating a unified access to health and mental health resources because as all the other candidates talked about, there's events that are important. But I think the main thing that we need to start on is making sure students feel safe and that they have all their access to resources.

Host: Thank you. Creating feedback is a critical part of the President's role. What is one specific platform, commitment or initiative that was shaped by consultation? Who did you consult and how did their input directly change or refine that part of your platform? For this we will start with Emily.

Emily Donjong: I think the most impactful consult I had during the sort of presidential preparation process would have been with the Food Collective Center. I think speaking to them, I really got a good handle of what students need in terms of food and security resources. I also got a really good understanding of what sort of expansions or new initiatives are actually possible under the FCC's current budget and volunteer capacities.

Host: Thank you. Next is Juliana.

JJ: The main thing I would focus on is Widgeon. I consulted with them a lot. But I also do have a lot of experience working as a queer advocate myself in athletics. I've had the role for three years. I did the work, I founded the space with the help of my friends and I created an area for me and identities that didn't exist before. And trans identities are at risk on campus. There's not enough services going into them and it's truthfully just systemic oppression and we're not willing to give more money to peer support resources. That is the only thing standing between us and equitable access to care for so many of us and so many different identities on campus.

Host: Thank you, Abdullah.

Abdullah Masoodi: So I've lived on campus for the last four years, both as a CA and a student. And a lot of the effort behind my food affordability side of my platform comes not only from my own experiences living on campus. But also from the dozens of students that I've mentored and supported. And I cannot begin to count how many times students have talked about how important food affordability is, not only as students living on campus, but also for commuters and other students who sometimes rely on the food on campus. Thank you.

Host: Olami.

Colin Scott: So for mine, the biggest one is the furniture give back program for first year students. When you look at fourth year students at the point they're graduating, they leave a lot of their stuff kind of on the street and that's a lot of, I guess, stuff for the city of Hamilton to clean up. A furniture give back program will ensure help first year students who are graduating away from or leaving first year and looking for housing as next year we're going to have the most first years ever living on campus and fourth year students who are graduating given a process for them to, I guess, give back those furniture to students who are looking for housing. And this also act as a way.

Host: Thank you.

Erin: One of my major points that took shape with consultations would have to be advocacy and solidarity, particularly what that looks like to different groups. In consultations with the MSA and mpsa, I learned that advocacy and solidarity might not be what I think it is to me, but to be tangible changes that allow these groups to operate and support students and, and feel empowered to stand up for their rights.

Host: Thank you, Maryam.

Erin: One of my main platform points that.

Emily Donjong: Was really bolstered by student consultation was with Yaseen Khan, our VP Admin, as well as numerous of our student coordinators for our services. And it's about generally how the student body interacts with our student services currently and how there is currently a promotions deficit and lack of proper dissemination of information amongst the student body and how to best use our services to promote us effectively.

Host: Thank you, Colin.

Colin Scott: When I was coming up with my platform, transparency wasn't a big part of it because it shaped most of everything that I was creating in it. But then when I went to consult with students throughout campus, they brought up with me how they don't really know what the MSU does with their tuition. Like a big part of our tuition goes towards the msu. They have no idea what they do with it. So that's a main point of why I decided to include transparency in my platform.

Host: And Christopher?

Christopher Xenos: Yeah, so the most important stakeholders that I spoke to during the campaigning period was just ordinary students, less MSU insiders on an issue of transparency. I also think that that should be tackled like in the last election I ran from when I was disqualified from. They didn't even tell me how many votes I got, which wasn't very fair.

Host: Thank you. And finally, Terry.

Terry: I think the most productive conversation I had was with the GM of emsu, Michael Wooder. We went over a lot of topics. We covered a lot of my platform. But I think it played a big part in informing the financial feasibility and the bureaucratic and administrative feasibility of my survey program that I want to get off the ground. So it was really productive in kind of making that idea into a reality through the avenues available in the MSU right now.

Host: Thank you. Our next question. The MSU operates in an increasingly complex environment, balancing student advocacy, service delivery, governance, and financial responsibility. With that in mind, what do you see as the most significant challenge currently facing the MSU and what concrete steps would you take as president to address it? For this question, we will begin with jj.

Host: Yes, I think with confidence. In my own opinion, I will say that there is a massive transparency issue. Trying to read through the budget is borderline impossible. I'm planning on going to law school after I get my degree and I'm struggling to access these resources. I'm struggling to understand the SRA resources. There's dead links everywhere. The only guide for running for president is this. Suppose the president had this thing. The link doesn't even work. There's not enough guidance. There's not an easy enough process to get involved. The information is there, but it is not accessible. And it's not fair to all the students that want to get involved and can't because of those barriers.

Host: Thank you, Abdullah.

Abdullah Masoodi: I think a big part of figuring out priorities and understanding what to what to prioritize is just talking to students. And not just students, but just all stakeholders. The more we

talk, the more information we get, the more focused our initiatives are. And as president, I would prioritize having those conversations, whether it means having like office hours, allowing students to step in and really get to learn from a low level basis what students are talking about.

Host: Thank you, Olami.

Host: So the biggest part of me of basically a lot of conversation I'd be having all week is students understand the student union as a whole. So my belief or my current scene of the student union is waiting for students to kind of come to know. My initiative is going to students first. Creating spaces for students to be able to access the student union as a whole. Creating events, creating or not. Just waiting for students as a whole to kind of, you know, meet us, tell us things that they want. But creating spaces for them to be able to access the services that we already do have, because a lot of them are under resources.

Host: Thank you, Erin.

Erin: In my opinion, the MSU does not act as a union or support its students at its current state. It's almost like a glorified club in the sense that students don't feel engaged or represented. If you look at the SRA General assembly, they've never reached quorum since 2014. On the BDS votes. Students really don't feel heard, they don't feel cared for. And that needs to change.

Host: Thank you, Marianne.

Emily Donjong: I think that one of the main issues that the MSU is facing right now, that there was a big gap in transparency in terms of advocacy. I think a lot of students are very frustrated in the way that the MSU is representing them and the way that they are uplifting their voices. And I think a lot of that frustration could honestly be quite mitigated by clearer transparency of what the SRA is doing and what the governance is doing on the students behalf.

Host: Thank you, Colin.

Colin Scott: Not to sound repetitive, but I think one of the main things that the MSU news focuses on is transparency. When I was researching my platform, I also looked into the budget. It was a pain to find. I found a page on the MSU website that said, what does the MSU do with your money? It Was updated in 2021. Doesn't seem very fair.

Host: Thank you, Christopher.

Christopher Xenos: Yeah, so I think the MSU is a bureaucratic, inefficient and wasteful institution. Like, why has the president paid more than \$50,000? Why do they receive subsidized housing? Why is it so expensive to run in elections? \$50 for a tape violation? And we have presidents that only want to waste more of the budget on pet projects.

Host: Thank you, Terry.

Terry: I think the. The biggest challenge the MSU faces right now has been the challenge it's faced for several years, which is engagement. I guess I'm preaching to the choir here because obviously

you guys are all at the debate, but election turnouts are still kind of low. Hopefully they'll be higher this year. The SRA can only manage single digit turnout. So I think the priority for the MSU going forward should be bridging the divide between a largely alienated student body and an MSU that currently isn't working as efficiently as it could be.

Host: Thank you.

Emily Donjong: Finally, Emily, I agree transparency is a huge issue. I think accountability is a huge issue as well. But I am going to echo Terry and say that the MSU's biggest issue is engagement. I think we have so many opportunities for students to be involved so many events. And it's really about breaking down those barriers that make it hard for students to come to campus and be engaged, like food insecurity, financial instability, academic stress, breaking down those things that make engagement difficult for our students.

Host: Thank you. On to our next question. As generative AI becomes increasingly influential in academic spaces, how would you use your role as president to support students in using these tools responsibly and effectively? What concrete steps would you take to address both the opportunities and challenges that come with generative AI at McMaster, including ethical concerns and the MSU's advocacy role? For this question, we will begin with.

Abdullah Masoodi: Abdullah Sure, A big focus of my platform is AI. Not necessarily pro AI or anti AI, but pro transparency and making sure when students enter the classroom they understand clearly what extent they're allowed to use AI or even if they're not allowed to use AI at all. The other aspect of my platform is improving literacy in AI. It's no secret again that AI is becoming more and more integrated in our workflow force and our productivity. And I think students should have the tools to be able to use AI to their advantage if they so choose.

Host: So thank you.

Host: I've had my own share of criticism in regards to AI in the past week and for me, AI is a tool. It is about how you use it and what you use it for as students here at the university. Anything you interact with AI generally, anything, a quick Google search Grammarly. But again, it's a tool to use to the best way for you to succeed as a student. It's not a shortcut. And then part of that is also working with the different facilities that we have at the university to see the best way we can best put students forward when it comes to their views.

Host: Thank you, Aaron.

Erin: I think to echo olamia bit, it's really important to note that AI seems to be in everything nowadays. You look up something on Google, there's AI, and that can be really difficult for students. And I think it's really important to have clarity in terms of course outlines when AI can be used, how it can be used, and that this should be developed in consultation with students as well as faculty with knowledge in the field.

Host: Thank you, Marian.

Emily Donjong: I echo the rest of my peers by saying that AI is everywhere now and academics is

no less. But I think it's also really important to support the AI paper that was written recently by the SRA and as well as the VP Education from last year year, because there is a lot of great work that was done in that. And a lot of great points that were brought up in terms of AI grading and how the clarity should be used between professor and student in the syllabus. And I think it's important to continue to support their work.

Host: Thank you, Colin.

Colin Scott: So AI is everywhere, as everyone has obviously said, but I think it can be used as a tool but outside of the classroom because we all pay thousands of dollars a year in tuition and we're here to learn. And I think my position as president would be to advocate for AI to be outside of education. And sure, you can have education on how to use it as a tool, but you're here to develop skills and you don't do that with AI.

Host: Thank you, Christopher.

Christopher Xenos: Yeah, so I think the use of generative AI, ultimately that should be up to the professors, not really the president. But on a personal note, I do think AI is making us a lot dumber. I mean, I personally know some people who really seem to use ChatGPT for like, every aspect of their lives.

Host: Thank you, Terry.

Terry: I think concerning the AI conversation, it's important to centralize the MSU president's role and it's largely an advocacy based role. So we're communicating with the authorities at the university to try and make sure that student voice is central to the ongoing AI conversation. I think there's no better way to have that conversation than to be informed, formed by student priorities. I think polling students directly and having their say in what their concerns are with AI is way more important than me stating my opinions on the topic.

Host: Thank you, Emily.

Emily Donjong: I think as an academic institution, it is really important that the university and the MSU acknowledges the presence of AI. I think it decreases the anxiety and the fear that students have about it being so present. I'm a ta, so I've seen it firsthand. And one of the really sort of prevalent pillars of my platform is a collaboration with Student Success on building an AI literacy campaign that helps students understand how AI can help them learn, but not do the learning for them. Really framing it as a tool.

Host: Thank you. And Juliana, my two hot takes on.

Host: AI are that one that we need distinct policy that's going to protect students from the use of generative AI and sexual exploitation. So the creation of images of our peers. There's no distinct policy, the rules are very vague. The second thing is on AI, I think using AI as a tool allows the university to circumvent their responsibility of teaching us how to engage with content critically. I think there needs to be more restrictions on first years in their usage of AI in courses, professors as well. And then I think it should be introduced in later years. And if we don't do that, why are we

here? Like, we're here to learn and engage critically. And if you don't do that, you are at the mercy of the information the AI presents you.

Host: Thank you. Onto our next question. In March 2015, undergraduate students at McMaster University, through the annual General assembly, voted for the MSU to join the international Boycott, Divestment and Sanctions BDS movement by divesting from companies that profit from, and I quote, Israeli war crimes, occupation, and the oppression of Palestinians. End quote. Since then, SRA members and students have continued to advocate for divestment, particularly calling on the MSU to pressure McMaster University as an institution to divest from entities connected to the ongoing genocide in Gaza. As MSU president, how would you respond to these calls for divestment and for this question, we will begin with Alami. Okay.

Host: Part of being the MSU president is speaking on behalf of the students, the students voice. You're essentially the spokesperson for the student union, and when it comes to any matter how small, how big, our little or whatever, the matter is yours, to represent the voice of the student union on a larger scale, not just on a small scale, but again, it's taken the voices from the students through, I guess, speaking with the students, speaking with the SRA and seeing the decisions and things that they decided and then taking matters upon the university and pressuring the university to do things that the student wanted.

Host: Thank you, Aaron.

Erin: I am in full support of pressuring the university to follow with BDS from the Israeli occupation and continued genocide in Palestine. I think we need to not be afraid to say that, and I think that it's something that the students obviously care about as we have passed that BDS motion. And I think that continued advocacy is key, and it's something I do in my role as Senate and something I want to do as the MSU president.

Host: Maryam.

Emily Donjong: I honestly echo Erin wholeheartedly. I think that conscientious reinvestment is extremely important. I am in full support of this completely. And I think we should not be scared of saying that there's a genocide happening in Palestine. I think this is a very telling thing, and we can see within the student body that this is a very, very pressing issue for them, and this is something that they want to be listened to, then they deserve to be listened to, and it should be pressed against the university.

Colin Scott: Colin, I fully support divestment, and I'll do everything in my power to make sure that I can help that.

Christopher Xenos: CHRISTOPHER yeah, if there's campus wide support for divesting, then of course we should do it. But ultimately I don't know if the president really has the authority to do that. And if they don't, I think the president should have more authority.

Terry: TERRY As I understand the question, it's more of an advocacy role that the MSU president would play to the university in their efforts. This is a role I'd be happy to fulfill and I think platforming student voices directly makes that argument much more credible than the current situation on

campus where we aren't directly engaging with student voices.

Emily Donjong: EMILY the ongoing genocide is affecting a variety of communities on our campus. I believe strongly in divestment and reinvestment and if the students feel strongly about that as well, it is my duty as the elected president to propel those voices as well as use the leverage that I have in this role within the MSU to hold the university accountable to what the students want.

Host: JJ Yes, I echo a lot of.

Host: What everyone has said. I think that there's a lot of experts on campus that have the ability to educate individuals on the complex histories that go into these subjects and we have failed miserably to do so. We have not done our role to educate our peers. We have not done our role to counter decades of anti-Semitism on campus. You can divest from Israel, which is 100% something I support you to do. But we also need to keep in mind that there are multiple student identities that are affected by this and we must protect, protect all of them, not just one of them.

Host: And finally, Abdullah, of course, I think.

Abdullah Masoodi: The university's response, especially from the senior administration level in regards to what students are saying about Palestinian activism has been nothing short of oppressive. Whether that's the suspension of sphr, whether that's the lack of integrity when it comes to things like listening to calls for divestment. I think it is incumbent on the MSU president and the MSU to advocate for students want to divest from the university, whether that's internally in the MSU or the university as a whole.

Host: Moving on to our final question for this portion of the debate. Bill 33, Ontario Supporting Children and Students act, was passed on November 20, 2025. The legislation grants the provincial government new authority to regulate the types of student fees that post secondary institutions may charge and requires universities to publicly disclose the criteria used to assess student applications. What aspect of Bill 33 do you find most concerning or impactful for post secondary students. And what amendments or advocacy actions would you prioritize as MSU president to better support students? We will have Erin to start us off.

Erin: Bill 33, like just about everything the current provincial administration has done, has been used to strip universities and educational bodies of their ability to support their students. Going into Bill 33 and looking at it specifically, I'm going to be honest, I'd probably need some more time to consult with students and see what students specifically care about. But that's something that I think is really important to push back against, especially with an administration that does not care.

Emily Donjong: However, what I do know is that McMaster already does it. Excellent, excellent job at providing, if you look for it carefully enough, a breakdown of your financial and how the MSU uses it, which is something that the Bill 33 is demanding that they do. And I think that it's important that we need to, as a student union and as a student body, kind of push for the fact that these things are already occurring and that we need to sort of.

Host: Thank you, Colin.

Colin Scott: I'm going to be honest, I haven't looked much into Bill 33 specifically, but the Ford government has been doing terrible things to post secondary education and everything across the Ontario government. So I have to look into it and see what the students think.

Host: Christopher yeah.

Christopher Xenos: So my thoughts on this are, I mean, like if the last president couldn't even build an ice Rick on campus, how are we going to oppose the provincial government? On the topic of Bill 33, like some of the other candidates, I haven't read up about it either. But if you speak to most people on campus, they have no IDEA what Bill 33 is. But if I were president, ultimately I would look at it and if there's anything we can do, if it's bad for the school, then of course I'd fight it.

Christopher Xenos: That's crazy.

Host: Terry.

Terry: Yeah. I think it's no secret if you explore my platform how much I loathe this piece of legislation. I think it's circumvents the authority majority of our student democracy. But I think it's much easier to do when students have been so disengaged on campus. I think it's about time that the MSU started doing more outreach, getting students more engaged, especially with our SRA and our presidential elections. So I think bridging that divide is going to be crucial. Also, enhancing financial transparency on the MSU website would be a great first step. I think there's not enough Emily I echo Terry.

Emily Donjong: I think transparency is super important. I think the most important concerning part about Bill 33 is the aspect of ancillary fees or that supplementary fee piece. A lot of important services on our campus are funded by these fees that students pay into and they are at risk of, you know, being defunded if these fees are made optional. However, I think we are extremely community oriented and we understand the importance of paying into these fees and I think that will work to combat some of the consequences of this bill.

Host: Thank you. Jj.

Host: Yeah, this would be a hot take. There are literally Nazis on the streets of downtown Hamilton and this stuff is very serious and we don't talk about this enough. And Bill 33 is a direct attack on affirmative action, on EDG rules, on all these things. This institution's finance or financial projected for next year is aimed to increase information for indigenous students alone. But we can't even have genuinely equitable truth and reconciliation conversations or events where we have to get into arguments with administration. That's university about not why we shouldn't play the Canadian national anthem. Like the Bill 33 is attack on our rights.

Emily Donjong: Sorry, I went over time, Abdullah.

Abdullah Masoodi: A big issue that the Ford government has is that skepticism and how, you know, student unions and universities are, you know, charging students and stuff. I don't think a lot of that skepticism was warranted towards groups like the msu. The MSU has done pretty decent job at explaining how student fees are broken down. Like in that guidebook that students get, like right at

the start of welcome week, one of the first pages is breaking down how your msu, how your EMERSU fees are broken down. And I think we should be focusing on showcasing.

Host: Thank you. MSU is a lot of me.

Host: So the biggest part of students and the student union itself is students at the university not understand what the student union does for them. I feel like the more that we educate students or show students the importance of the student union, the better we can best serve them. Something we also do have is we have OUSA. And part of USA's responsibility is working with other universities. And the more voices that you do have, the better you can advocate for the students that you have under your consistence. And part of that is Bill 33 and combating against Bill 33 from the point of view of students and the student organizations that we have across Ontario.

Host: Thank you. And with that, this portion of debate has concluded. Please invite me in a round of applause with our four candidates. Okay, stop. We will now move into the open debate and rebuttal period. As a reminder, this is the period for Candidates to to freely rebut any comments made by your opponents or question another candidate on one of their platform points and how it will be achieved. This period will last for about 10 minutes. Each candidate will get exactly two 30 second speaking terms. In other words, you can add your name to the speakers list twice and only twice to respond or question another candidate on the screen stage. There will be no particular order. If no candidate has any rebuttals, we will move right into the audience question period. To add yourself to the speakers list, please raise your hand. When I acknowledge that your hand has been raised, I will nod at you and then you may put it down. The same rules as the question period apply. We have Vidya and Jasmine sitting in the front row who will serve as our timekeepers, as they have. They will raise a yellow card when you have 15 seconds left to speak and a red card when your time is up. As a reminder for the audience, if you have a question you would like to ask one of the candidates, please indicate so in the chat. If you are watching online or if you are in person, scan the QR code above the candidates. So let's get to it. Would anyone like to be added to the speakers list? We will start with Terry.

Colin Scott: Do I go now?

Colin Scott: Side question.

Host: Sorry.

JJ: Do we have to ask questions to people individually specifically or can we propose it to the group?

Host: Well, one person has to respond. Okay. Multiple people want to respond. That will count towards their 32nd speaking turn. So if you do direct it towards the group and everyone wants to respond, that will count as one of their turns.

Host: Okay. Thank you very much. I appreciate it.

Terry: So does that mean I get to start now or.

Host: Terry, you can start now.

Terry: Thank you. I think a lot of folks on this stage have talked about engagement concerns. They've talked about being your voice, amplifying your voice. I think that's great. What I'm proposing is a little bit different. I'm proposing a platform that allows you to be your own voice, that celebrates individual student priorities and makes them institutionally legible so that we can all. So that we can all have an MSU that reflects what students want to see on campus.

Host: Thank you, jj.

Host: I think the step program that you've pitched is amazing. I do think that your program is very reliant on it. But I said this to you earlier. I think there's something to be said about the commodification of suffering on campus. And yes, it's great that you get a gift card for sharing your opinion, but when are we actually going to see change happen. There is survey burnout that is documented. Nothing changes at the school no matter how many times we say it. So, so what? Now it's a thing and I get a gift card for it. Great. I'll go buy myself a Starbucks coffee to like appease for the fact that I just got hate crimes. So how are you going to protect us regarding those things? Sorry, I don't know if that's. I don't know the form of debate. I don't know how to ask questions back at him.

Host: So sorry, Olami.

Host: So for me, it comes down to as well, Terry, when you look at surveys, people already have problems like homeworks and assignments and different things like that. I feel like when you are answering a survey only speaks on specific people's voices. People are willing to go and fill out the surveys. This doesn't speak on the like speak on everyone. My platform is kind of about bringing meeting people in place, clarity or creating avenues for students to speak their voices. Not 20 questions on, you know, Microsoft Teams or something like that. Just again.

Emily Donjong: Emily, in my consultations with the MSU general manager, I was informed that looking into something like the expansion of the soup and bread program program wasn't necessarily feasible in terms of itemized costs as well as like labor that would go into that. So I am just kind of curious in terms of any candidates who are proposing an expansion of that program, what the feasibility and the logistics behind that proposal look like.

Host: Olami, what did you want to go again? No. Would anyone else like to be added to the speaker's list to respond? Abdullah, this is your second speaking term. You may go ahead.

Host: Sure.

Abdullah Masoodi: I really do appreciate the idea of student engagement. I think that focus is a little bit misdirected. A big part of my platform has been shifting the conversation away from talking about engagement, but talking said about cultures, which is what I defined as things outside of the classroom that tie people to this campus. That's a big reason why I'm committed to investing in those things outside of the classroom, like athletics, like arts, like clubs. I think those are the conversations we should be having and prioritizing.

Host: Thank you. That is the end of our speakers list.

Erin: Erin, in response to the inquiry about an expanded soup and bread program, my initiative, my campaign promise was to go from 75,000 to 200,000 meals because currently there's a great demand for the soup and bread initiative, but it runs out quickly and we also don't have it on Mondays and Fridays. This would take place through funding of a referendum where students could get to voice their actual opinions on whether this is something they feel valuable.

Host: Thank you. We have Christopher.

Christopher Xenos: So I've heard some of the candidates ideas and I like some of them. Like the soup and bread idea. It's just the question that I think of is like, how is the school going to pay for all this stuff? I mean, I've heard the school has a lot of budget issues as is, and then I hear issues, you know, like one of the candidates, I'm sorry to call them out, but, you know, like putting bidets in the toilets, like things like that. I don't really know if we need interactive toilets. It's just, it's. These things are all expensive and I don't know how any of them are going to pay for it.

Host: Okay, next we have Colin.

Colin Scott: Okay, there's a lot to address there.

Colin Scott: First of all.

Colin Scott: The soup and bread. She just said that it would be funded through a referenda. Also coming from. Know what a referenda it. You know what a referenda is?

Terry: You know what it does.

Christopher Xenos: Yeah, but where's the money that's supporting that referendum?

Host: Christopher, we will have order.

Colin Scott: It would be an increase to your.

Colin Scott: It would.

Colin Scott: We had a referendum last year where.

Host: Christopher.

Terry: It would be like.

Host: We are going to have order for.

Colin Scott: The \$6 to increase it.

Host: Colin, we will restart with your time. We are going to have decorum. Ladies and gentlemen.

Colin, you may begin again.

Colin Scott: Honestly, I don't even know what to say. But okay. Soup and Brad. It would only be like another \$6 if we expended Monday to Friday like some of the other candidates were talking about, in bidets. It's something cheap.

Colin Scott: You can.

Colin Scott: Can put it everywhere on campus. That's a great idea. I realize I'm talking about other people's platforms, but. Sorry I had to be put in that position.

Host: We have jj, this is your second speaking turn.

Host: Oh, God, I just lost my train of thought. I think that we need to respect the validity of this process. And it's easy to make light of things and it's easy to disrupt, like, the formality of the circumstance and this occasion. I. I don't know how a debate works, but this isn't a place to argue. And I think it really shows the issues. Like, I'm not trying to accuse you of stirring the pot, but there are things on campus like food accessibility. Yeah, FCC would be great. Or we could just petition to the institution to not make this food super inaccessible to us. Like, yeah, it's great. We're expanding free services, but why are we each other's caregivers when this institution is supposed to support us?

Host: Thank you. Erin, this is your second speaking term.

Erin: To speak a bit more to my notion on bidets, this is actually not something new. There are bidets at UTSC and utm. I spoke with the girl who started that initiative. That's where I got the figures for funding from. And it would be \$600 per commercial bidets, mostly due to labor. And to have that six bidet pilot project in high needs areas based on 200 student surveys at McMaster, we would place those bidets in the hub and in musk near the prayer and in the hub near prayer spaces and in the mosque. And that would cost 13 cents per student.

Host: Thank you. Olami, this is your second speaking term. Okay.

Host: For me, when it comes to food, food is a big issue for students. Just generally everyone on campus. I'm not spending almost \$14 every single day to get a breakfast either in piazza or something from Central for lunch. So it's about advocating for students and speaking to the universities in ways we can develop different programs to help reduce the cost of food on campus. Part of that is seen if the highest selling items can be reduced in price. And items that usually sell not as much if you increase them in price, it's not really going to affect too much of the profit margin.

Host: Thank you. Would anyone else? Terry, this is your second speaker.

Terry: I think a lot of the concerns many of my peers have brought up are very centered on advocacy, and I think it's a big part of the role. What's more compelling, I think, than being MSU president and your mandate as MSU president? President is being backed by data, being backed by student priorities directly. It's great to go up to the university and say, hey, we need to spend

more money on food accessibility. We have concerns about AI. If we have hard data that we can turn to, those conversations become a whole lot easier and they represent your views way more directly. So I think that's something to keep in mind going forward.

Host: Thank you, Colin.

Colin Scott: So we already have lots of data on how university students in general feel about a AI. We also have this election where you're voting for someone who goes with your values. We don't need to deal with surveys all the time that are going to cost the university more money that we don't have just to get information that we already have.

Host: Would anyone else who has not exhausted their speaking terms. Christopher, this is your second speaking term.

Christopher Xenos: Yeah. I'd just like to reiterate that you know, tuition is expensive as is, and it's just all the other candidates they've provided proposed many ways to spend money, not necessarily to save it.

Host: Would anyone else like to add to the speakers list who have not exhausted their two speaking terms?

Emily Donjong: Maryam I just want to pop in really quickly on the notion of food and bread. In my own consultation about food and bread finance, it did seem to me that there would be some way to work within the budget to expand this, as well as my consultation with the FCC as to make sure that their volunteer bandwidth could cover it. Other than that, I think there is no harm in advocating towards the university. As it's been seen, that is a great student need and about big value add to student life on campus.

Host: Last call.

Host: Does anyone have a turn left?

Host: All right, well, thank you very much, candidates for an interesting rebuttal section. We will now move into the audience question period. For this period, candidates will each have 30 seconds to answer each question. When asked our first question, humility is a key concept of leadership. What is a gap in your plan or platform that another candidate has done a better job filling? What might you learn from them? For this section, we will begin with Miriam.

Emily Donjong: I think that there may be a little bit of a gap in my plan to gain student engagement in terms of a student section with athletics. That I think Abdullah might do a little bit better than me. That I think I could learn a lot from. That is off the top of my head, what I think.

Christopher Xenos: Colin so I think when I was.

Colin Scott: Making my platform, I made it focused on what the MSU provides for you. I think a gap in my platform would be that I didn't really focus on the advocacy that we could do for students. I think JJ did that really well because she's been really on that about advocacy for students of all

backgrounds.

Host: Christopher I'm just going to say I.

Christopher Xenos: Like my campaign so far. I'm just going to keep it at that.

Terry: Terry yeah, I want to give full credit to Olami. His idea to get the MSU involved in charity and start accepting donations is a fantastic idea. I wish I had come up with it myself. I'd really love to see something like that implemented, and I wish it was in my platform because it's absolutely fantastic.

Emily Donjong: Emily I think an area I could have improved on in my platform was just my consults. There were a couple areas that I think would have really been strengthened by speaking to some of those essential sort of stakeholders and some of my larger ideas. I think that Miriam did an excellent job and was extremely thorough with the people that she talked to and I have a lot of respect for that.

Terry: I just have to pat everyone on the back that has a lot of more involvement with the Ms. You like kind of your sentiments. I was very impressed with all the consultation that went into this. It was really nice to see one person I really wanted to compliment that I've been glancing all day. Terry phenomenal writer. His writing in the MSU in the sill was something that was really inspirational, influential to me and I didn't actually realize we're going to be running against each other. And so I just really appreciate, you know, diving deeper in past the MSU and into actual government legislation.

Host: Abdullah sure.

Abdullah Masoodi: One thing I pride of myself in this case campaign is making sure the initiatives I do propose are, you know, focused and direct and have concrete actions. I think one thing I wish I incorporated more was kind of showing off my creative side and implementing some more creative ideas and things that students might be interested which is why I really appreciate some of the things Alami has brought up. I think we always need people who are, you know, dreaming big and have big ideas and I'm not saying that none of the things are like infeasible, but I do appreciate, appreciate your thinking and finding things that appeal to students.

Abdullah Masoodi: Allow me, for me it's kind of been Christopher, to be honest, personally like being in this position. It's very hard to stand here, especially being a first year student, standing in front of the entire students here at the university and being someone as well who's been disqualified from a different campaign and you know, choosing to come back again and putting yourself in the entire face of the university is something that takes bravery and great strength. Again, all the individuals here like again, it takes a lot to be here in front of people, speaking and looking directly in your faces.

Christopher Xenos: Man, Olami, you're my new favorite.

Erin: Aaron I think one thing I really struggled with with my campaign was the translation of my ideas from my brain to the students. And one person I, I think who did that really well was Emily.

Like her campaign is gorgeous. Whoever's on her media team, including her, did a really good job and I loved all her videos and I was like, damn, she got all the good ideas. So I would say that's one thing I'd like to improve like my communication skills in that regard. So you go Emily.

Emily Donjong: Thank you.

Host: Thank you. Our next question. Many students have noticed an increasing special constable and police presence on campus, including reports of false arrest, facial racial profiling and Surveillance cameras. As president, how should the MSU engage with special constables and police? And how would you support students concerned about this trend?

Colin Scott: We'll start with Colin I don't exactly know what as president I would be able to do, but in terms of advocacy, I would advocates McMaster administration to try to try to calm down the presence of special constables because we've seen issues with policing, higher policing on campus. It creates an unsafe environment that no one really wants to be here for.

Host: CHRISTOPHER.

Christopher Xenos: So on the issue of the police constable, so obviously, since I'm only in my second semester, I don't know too much about previous instances of, you know, constables treating students poorly, but I'd love to hear student instances of that occurring and I'd work to solve that if there was an issue.

Terry: Terry yeah, I'd be the first to say I'm not fully aware of the full scope of this issue, but I would totally agree that the campus area is over police. I don't think it's just a campus issue. I think it's also a municipal issue. And a big part of our advocacy, I think, should be informed by these student priorities and ensuring that our rights as citizens, first and foremost are being upheld in every regard. So that would be a big portion, I think, of my advocacy work regarding this issue.

Emily Donjong: EMILY I think this is definitely an advocacy piece here and bring them to the special constables. From my consultations, I've heard that they are open to dialogue and open to conversation. I think that conveying what's happening to students here is really important and also just saying it like it is. Students are uncomfortable, they're not feeling protected, they're not liking what they're seeing and we need to take that into account.

Host: Thank you.

Host: J.J. if I wanted to go to a campus where there was armed officers, I would have gone to school in the States. All of the DEN resources, all of the anti racism reports that we have show that there's systemic racism at this institution on this campus. We know that there is an issue with racism and police forces. We know that they are inherently impressive. And if the university had done more to engage in civil conversation and get opposing groups to talk to each other, maybe there shouldn't have been so much. There wouldn't have been so much fear and maybe people wouldn't have tended to violence. But it's an absolute, utter scapegoat for this institution to deny their responsibility in their inaction.

Host: ABDULLAH.

Abdullah Masoodi: I think the advocacy part and talking to security services is great. I think before that we should be prioritizing listening to these students and hearing their experiences. One thing I'd like to see more from MSU administration is more of an open forum for students, allowing students to come to the board of directors and talk about these. Not just talking, but genuinely listening as well. I think that's the first step before we go and advocate at the higher level.

Abdullah Masoodi: Olami so something that you are as the MSU president is that you need to have a lot of connections or relationships with different people or faces on campus. I currently have a decent relationship when it comes to anyone from Neo Donato or even Tucci on campus. And part of that is leaving that relationship to understand the reasoning as to why they're present in these spaces. So part of that could be, you know, telling them to lessen, you know, their security or lessen the presence of police in these places. Because I feel like overall, protests, overall are all important in regards to getting your point across. A lot of the times people are not going to listen to you. Like, no, sorry, Aaron.

Erin: As JJ has mentioned, it's really important that we acknowledge the inherent oppressive origins of policing and how that continues into present day, especially in silencing and targeting protesters. Right. So special constables are currently being used as a tool to silence that dialogue and to silence student voices. And I don't think that, you know, that's conducive to a learning environment. And I think that's something we do have to be against.

Host: And lastly, Miriam, I think it's really.

Emily Donjong: Important to acknowledge the fact that our campus is a little bit over policed. What I do know is that with the increase of special constables following people home, making false arrests, especially to those who are a little bit more politically active, it's really important to, I know that MSU currently is having conversations frequently with special constables, and I think it's important to continue that as well as ensure that everyone knows their rights in terms of them, knows what they can do, knows what they can't do, and how to protect themselves as a service student body.

Host: Thank you. For our next question the audience has asked. Leaders must be capable of growing with new information or changing circumstances. What is one example of something or someone who has shifted your perspective during this campaign? For this question, I'll start with Christopher.

Christopher Xenos: So since I'm only in my first semester, sorry, second semester, I've spoken to a lot of people that have, that have influenced my opinion. Pretty much every student or second student I speak to tells me something that I haven't yet learned about. The school. And I've learned a lot. Learned about what?

Christopher Xenos: People.

Christopher Xenos: I've spoken to a lot of first year students. I've learned that affordability really is the biggest concern. And then from my own experiences too, running in the first year council election, that was a complete disaster with the tape violations and the 50. You all are fine. I've learned a lot.

Terry: Terry Yeah, I think over the course of this campaign, it's been such a great opportunity to speak with the student body. I've been so engaged more than I ever have been with individual people at McMaster and they've been super informative. I've learned a lot about specific concerns that people have had, especially with clubs, with services, with our events and our engagement. And I do think it's reinforced my view that centralizing and having a platform where we can share these concerns and making them accessible through data is going to be really, really impactful going forward.

Emily Donjong: Emily I think through all of the consultations that I consulted through this process, I really did kind of develop a better understanding of where we can actually have meaningful change on our campus. I brought a lot of ideas to these consultations that ultimately just weren't deemed feasible or weren't deemed something that we could actually achieve. But on the other side of that, I realized there is so much opportunity, opportunity for expansion and growth. And if elected, I am committed to pursuing all of those opportunities.

Terry: Juliana yeah, I spent all of winter semester recovering from a knee surgery and learning how to walk. So in a way, I miss the fear mongering and I'm not scared of this institution, what they have to say. And you know, I'm talking, I'm talking with trans folks that are telling me we can't even respect their names. Everyone. This institution calls me jj. It's a nickname. We can't even call people by their names. Like, seriously, there's just so many things and like, you know, I accidentally said that I got hazed during the live lounge now means I have to commit to the bit and go after athletics, which I'm going to do. But, you know, it really radicalized me. There's so we, we're all playing the game and none of us are getting the prizes we were promised. And there's.

Host: Thank you, Abdullah.

Abdullah Masoodi: My campaign team members have heard me talk about this countless over this campaign. But one of my favorite things about campaigning, whether that's boothing and musk or that's going to on campus, is just talking to students, just hearing them and, you know, figuring out what they're hearing, feeling, thinking. It's been so refreshing. I've really never had an opportunity like this to directly engage with the student body so critically and so directly. It's been such a refreshing opportunity.

Host: Olami.

Colin Scott: So my kind of goes in part on two folds. One of them is speaking to students. I'm a yapper. So kind of speaking to students on a day, weekly basis. It's one I got tested to my limits. But then the second thing is kind of like when you have enough people to believe in you, you believe that you can do anything. So for me, it's been my campaign team. Everyone from Kathuja to my brother to Olivia to Stephen to Isa and first year to Darius. When you have enough people that have the same view that you do and the goal that you do, you can achieve any goals that you want.

Host: Thank you, Aaron.

Erin: Through my consultations with numerous clubs and organizations, I've learned that funding is not necessarily the main barrier, but that there are organizational barriers that stop groups from

doing what they really need to, who.

Emily Donjong: Have a lot of issues with how things are currently run. And I think they have a lot of great points and there's a lot of things that need to be changed, as well as shout out my commuters. They are angry about the buses and they do not hesitate to let you know. Noted.

Host: And finally, Colin, it's really hard to.

Colin Scott: Single out someone in particular who helped me with designing my platform the most. But when I started off designing my platform, it had a million different promises that weren't really achievable. And I'd say my campaign team helped me refine that and create something that I think will help me best represent you, the students here.

Host: Thank you. Thank you. On to our next audience question. Universities have always been a place where students can exchange substantively in ideas, debate, and have the rights and freedoms to protest in what they believe in. How will you ensure that the university remains a free and fair arena for students to speak freely? I'll begin with Terry.

Terry: Yeah, this is, I think, central to the university experience. I think it's central to the Canadian experience. This is something that should be happening on campus. I am absolutely 100% for students, sharing their voices, being heard, being listened to. And that's a big part of, I think, why I started running is that I want to see more engagement on campus. I want to see student priorities and student voice become more centralized, another platform to.

Terry: Not doing so. So that we do not have a free marketplace of ideas and we can gather as a community. We must not suffer from the community standard. Majority should not rule at this institution. There are literally Nazis on the street. That was not a thing when I was here in first year. And we do need to start getting a little bit worried.

Abdullah Masoodi: Abdullah in my opinion, one of the most foundational parts of the university experience is being able to discuss pressing issues, whether it's politics, whatever the case is. The function of the university is not to dictate those politics. It's to allow a safe and free platform to discuss these in an intellectual way. I think, as president, I want to focus that focus on continuing to provide those opportunities, whatever that looks like.

Host: Thank you, Olami.

Host: For me, it's university has always been like, you know, the future goal I've always had in mind, and also the future goal a lot of our parents have also had in mind for us and kind of coming to university, what is an institution if things are not being questioned? So for the university also serves as a space for students to have questions about how things are going on and, you know, in the world that we live in today. So, for me, a safe platform should be given to all students who have any issues that they feel like need to be represented. Just, you know, give them a voice.

Erin: Aaron it's important that we hold McMaster accountable for ensuring that their messaging aligns with actual laws and university policies, particularly in regards to being against hate speech, while allowing for and allowing for student protest, which was not rooted in policies. And I have

been pushing back against this in Senate, and I hope it's something that we all can agree to do.

Emily Donjong: Marianne I echo Erin and a couple of the other candidates when saying that it is very important to hold McMaster accountable as an institution, as well as the fact that this is a place of growth, this is a place of being able to uplift your voice and have your voice be heard and seek other perspectives. And I have a kind of an issue with the question in itself, because it says, how can it remain a safe place to express your opinions when I don't think that it currently is.

Colin Scott: Poor Palestinian protests and McMaster special constables are sitting there and they're intimidating everyone.

Christopher Xenos: Christopher yeah, so I think students definitely should feel comfortable to express themselves. And I'll say, as president, I would make it easier and cheaper for students to get involved in student affairs. I think that's what matters most for being able to express yourself in university. Like, next year, I think there should be even more candidates up on this stage.

Host: Onto our next question. Throughout the year, as president, you will be faced with Unforeseeable obstacles and redirection. You've shared your priorities. What's the first one you'd sacrifice if you had to switch focuses? And what does this say about your leadership? I'll begin with Emily.

Emily Donjong: I think the initiative I would probably sacrifice would unfortunately be of the media spotlights that I propose for small businesses that are attached to my larger small business initiative. I think the only reason I'd be willing to sacrifice an initiative like that is because in my platform and in my goals, I have a larger initiative that would still achieve the end goal of supporting small businesses and student ideas on campus. So the end goal would still be achieved even if that smaller piece was removed.

Host: Sorry, J.J. no worries.

Host: My platform changed. It's new, updated one. Go check it out if you haven't seen it yet. I think the one that I would cave on first would be the network for bridging clubs and athletic services together. I think they're important, but, you know, making documents more accessible, focusing on like inaccessible resources for male mental health, specifically advocating for students. Like, it's really hard to say that I would cave on those things versus something that's more related to student life.

Abdullah Masoodi: Dylan I think it's a tough question to answer. I mean, when I was building my platform, I didn't have a notion of one thing being more important than the other or having to sacrifice one of them or anything. I think if anything, because my student culture platform is so large, maybe looking at focusing on certain parts of it over others at this moment, I can't really say which one, but it's definitely an interesting thing to think about.

Abdullah Masoodi: Alami yeah, this is a difficult question still, I can't lie. But personally for me, I'll say like the homecoming aspect of things, homecoming, it's big, it's important for growing the school culture and the student culture here. But when I look at like day to day issues, homecoming is one day out of, you know, eight months that we're here at the university. So again, it's about

creating spaces for students here at the university to interact with the student union and. My bad. But homecoming can go still.

Erin: Erin I think one aspect of my campaign that if I had to cut, would probably be part of my comfy campus. So right now I am advocating for free breakfast as well as expanding soup and bread. But I think that in this case it might make sense to pause expanding soup and bread in absence of having a breakfast program as well. I think there's a bit of overlap in that case, but otherwise it really is hard to pick. It's like killing your darlings after you put all this effort into thinking about it. But you know, that's a part of being the president.

Emily Donjong: MARYAM I would say if I had to pick something specifically, it would either be the implementation of Frost Week or anything to do with hoco. Ultimately, there is no point of student life really if people cannot have the baseline accessibility concerns that they have on this campus to have a the quality of life that is necessary to enjoy any of the student life and advocacy pieces presented.

Colin Scott: COLIN it's really hard to choose one thing to take out of my platform because when I was designing it, of course, like everyone else, we mesh it together. But I'd have to go with, I would stop the expansion of hours for MSC services like 1280, like the, like the Hub, because I think the rest of my platform is amazing on its own. And if we have the engagement, the well being and transparency, we can make MSU so much better.

Christopher Xenos: Christopher yeah, so my platform focus is purely on affordability, making the MSU less bureaucratic and more accessible to students. I'm not going to sacrifice that. I'm going to commit to that. I can also say that I won't put money into things like in the toilet for bidets.

Host: Terry yeah.

Terry: I think it's tough to choose. I hope I get through everything. If there was one thing I had to cut, I think it would be my proposed collaboration with Bird. The electric scooter providers in Hamilton, they have a community pricing initiative. I wanted to get on campus. What does that say about me? I guess I'm not as pro transit accessibility. I'm more pro engagement. I think that's the big problem. I think the MSU face basis. So I definitely devote more of my time on bridging that divide.

Host: Thank you all. Our next student question. Off campus, student matters are often neglected and not central to candidates direct audiences. As president, what actions might you take to ensure their support in subjects like the infrequency of bus schedules and the difficulty of conduct commuting? We'll start with jj.

JJ: I've never been a full commuter student. I have a car. But in recent years I did use GO services. I feel like a lot of focus on transit advocacy at this university is like making it more fun or building social bridges or HSR GO passes and stuff. But I'm just like, what actual heart advocacy are we really doing for commuters? Like can we not just focus all of our resources on getting more bus lines to happen? Like I feel like that is what the people are asking for, it's quite clear and evident we should just do that.

Abdullah Masoodi: Abdullah it's kind of disheartening to see that not only has the university been constantly increasing enrollment beyond its means, but they've been cutting back on support for commuter students. In the last couple of years we've launched the Archway program, which was instrumental in providing support to students living off campus, especially first years. And we also lost the society of off campus students. And in the last couple years there's been a lack of support at an institutional level for commuter students. And that's something as MSU president, I'd like to explore bringing back Olami.

Abdullah Masoodi: So for me, the biggest thing is working with metrolinx and seeing the best way we can increase the services of buses at peak hours or peak times, especially throughout the week. You look at Friday evenings for example, every single first year on campus is going home and then you have the commuters also trying to get home as well. One, increasing the access of buses at those point, but then secondly, something for international students as well, having buses that usually run on the last week or weeks of exams that take students directly to one of the GO bus stops, the 40 that goes to Pearson Station, so they can get home easy.

Host: Thank you, Aaron.

Erin: I think previous candidates over the years have all mentioned that they would like to speak with metrolinx or go, but that has never really, really panned out. We've never particularly gotten major changes. While that's something I'd like to do, I think the university should also be focusing on what we can do. So that would be accessibility of classes, particularly for commuter students. For example, there's a midway between a snow day and perfectly great weather and sometimes it's really hard for commuter students to get to school. Looking at making classes online for those days and more accessible so you don't have to rush through snow.

Emily Donjong: Marion One of the demonstrated issues that commuters have brought up to me a lot over the last week is the busing schedules and it actually more so than people coming from Saga on the GO bus, but it really is also about people coming from Hamilton itself. I think we do a lot of great job surveying people coming from those other places through Metrolink services, but not a great job in figuring out what bus routes need to have increased frequency for people coming from farther up the mountain and beyond.

Colin Scott: Colin Just to add on, working with metrolinx to get more bus schedules is a little bit of a challenge because the Premier of Ontario is Doug Ford and I don't Think he wants to support us. But aside from that, a lot of students that I talked to who are commuters, they spoke about how, oh, I have a 9am class and then the next class at 3pm So I just sit on my laptop in Mills and I do nothing. We should, as the msu, we should also work to create a more comforting campus that people have.

Host: Christopher yes.

Christopher Xenos: So I am a commuter student. So as president I would use my authority to try to make life easier not just for others, but of course for myself. But like, you know, I have to, I have to take the bus. I had to walk through a field to get to school earlier today. It was knee deep snow. So I understand the struggle that commuter students can go through.

Terry: Terry Yeah, I think the question of transit, the question of busing is largely a question of advocacy. And as it stands right now, the way the MSU does advocacy is they claim to be representative of the student body and they meet with key stakeholders. I think what would be more compelling than just claiming representation is having data we can turn to. I think commuter students have been kind of cast aside in the past. Providing them with the platform would go a long way. When we're having these meetings with Metrolinx, when we're having meetings with the HSR and we want to get changes done, having hard data to point to I think is really, really compelling.

Emily Donjong: Emily So I agree there is an element of advocacy here and I think that the president has the power to work in tandem with the Vice President of Education on things like HSR and Metrolinx, advocacy for things that the students want to see. We also need to target how commuting life manifests on campus campus, which is things like isolation and disconnect. I'm proposing a commuter mentorship program in my platform that would not only provide models of meaningful connections on campus, but also target that isolation and provide support for commuting students.

Host: Thank you everybody. We are now moving into our final audience question. Gender based and sexual based violence is a serious problem on post secondary campuses. Recently there have been abrupt staffing changes in the University's Sexual Violence Prevention and response office, SVPro, with limited transparency on how these structural changes impact students. How will you work with SV Pro and other campus groups to ensure students are still being supported and that we are working towards a campus free of gender based and sexual violence. For this question, we'll begin with Abdullah.

Abdullah Masoodi: Again, it's been really disheartening to see the, the again lack of transparency, the lack of follow up after the loss of a Lot of the structure of SVPro. Being a CA for the last couple years, it's been really important for me to be able to pass along this information to students and show them that there is a credible organization here to support you when these things come up. And in this past year it's been hard to tell students that. It's been hard to show that this is a credible thing. I think the Ms. You should be more focused on improving that.

Abdullah Masoodi: So when I look at SV Pro, especially on the part of the university, I sympathize with a lot of students who require the services, the SV program students here at the university. But then I also look inward and I see part of the services that our MSU also delivers for students and see the way that it's not being accessed or lack of access, especially when it comes on the hand of students finding out that we even have these services and programs in the first place. So again, my goal is to make sure students understand and know what the student union services are and see how we can best aid these services to aid students that require those.

Host: Thank you, Erin.

Erin: As a student and past CA who attended SV Pro training sessions and also recommended students to SV Pro, I was very disheartened when they were defunded and I noticed an immediate change in the quality of training and I think that that really impacts all levels of students. I think one way to target this would be putting pressure on them to rebuild SV Pro and also to allow resources like Sheck to recommend outside sources when McMaster does not have enough, such as Sacha.

Emily Donjong: Mary, I've had the pleasure of talking to the new SV Pro directors and hearing a lot about what they hope to implement and how the MSU can collaborate with them in terms of more event promotion as well as sort of all the initiatives they're planning to be more front facing with the student body as they were before the staff turnover. But it's also important to note that I consult with some people in Wien who think the SV Pro needs to be restructured a little bit in terms of how they deal with victims, specifically male victims. I've heard a lot about do not, did not in the past staffing turnover did not get enough light as they should have.

Host: Thank you, Colin.

Colin Scott: So we've seen the lack of transparency around how McMaster administration has dealt with SVPro and I think it's frankly disgusting. But it also shows how much they care about the students. They do the same thing in so many other areas, like they shut down protests or if they don't shut down protests. They'll have special constables intimidating the protesters, and there's no transparency on that. So the McMaster student union president has to be a strong advocate for that.

Christopher Xenos: Christopher okay, so I already know that nothing about this school is transparent or efficient. There's no doubt about that. But in this area in particular, I definitely think there should be no shortage of funding for things that are related to mental health or supporting students in being able to feel comfortable and safe on campus.

Host: Terry?

Terry: Yeah, I think this was really, really an unfortunate loss. I was really upset when I first heard about it, and I'm very disappointed. I think in the, in the university that there are these austerity measures and this is what they felt they needed to cut. I think a big part of the role is advocacy, and I want to make sure that the university is doing more as well. There are more services that I think they could be providing that they don't. And I think I look forward to working with them. Informed by your voice directly, we can make a lot of impactful change and work with the university to get some stuff done.

Emily Donjong: Emily I agree with Terry. I think the way that the SV.

Terry: Pro cut the Sexual Violence and Prevention Response Office. What are you talking about? Will is one of the service providers and leg exists because of work he did directly for us. It is absolutely ridiculous. And they're using this as a way to control our narrative through fear so we don't feel safe like it's sexual violence prevention. What do you mean? There was consent. Went 803 course. Why are you cutting the service compared to other things in this institution? And we have a balanced budget still.

Host: Thank you to all of our candidates for answering these questions from your future constituents. We are now moving into our closing statements. You each will only have 30 seconds to provide your closing remark. And we will go in alphabetical order, as we did for introductions. So we will begin with Terry.

Terry: Yeah. Thank you, everyone, so much for coming out today. It's been a real pleasure. I'm so

happy to share the stage with such fantastic people. It's such a great marketplace of ideals, and I'm so glad we have this platform to share our concerns on campus. It's been a really, really productive conversation. I hope you learned a lot. I know I have, and it's been a fantastic experience running thus far. It's been worth it already, so thank you all for your support, and let's see what happens.

Host: Emily.

Emily Donjong: This has been an absolutely incredible experience. I do want to thank everybody for showing up. Not Only today, but you know, to the booths at Musk and to talking to not only me, but to the rest of the candidates that I share the stage with. I think that it is wonderful to see so many people participating in democracy, even just on a campus level. And I hope that there is something in maybe not even just my platform, but in somebody's platform that resonates, resonates with at least everybody here so that you go out and you vote and you know, you elect somebody who you can see as your next president.

Host: JJ yeah, definitely echo a lot of the sentiments shared. I'm extremely grateful for the opportunity to do this after the crazy year I just had. I've been an advocate at this institution before. This role. If I assume this role, I will be an advocate and if I don't have the privilege of assuming this role, I continue to be an advocate. At the end of the day, that is what most is most important to me that folks know all we have is each other and all you have to do is vote. Coming to this debate is a huge way to get involved. Talk to your friends and do not wait. And like some, I'm in my fifth year, I'm running out of time and they're trying to sweat us out because there's such high turnover and that's why things don't change. Do not wait to get involved. Anything you do matters.

Abdullah Masoodi: Abdullah I could never have imagined, you know, if I was, if first year, thinking about being in a position like this, being able to talk to people directly. It has been such a unique experience. It's been such a fun experience, it's been such a fulfilling experience. And whatever the outcome of this election is, I want to thank everyone so much for showing up and talking and engaging. Please, please look into everyone's platform. We're all trying to make some meaningful changes. And again, thanks so much for coming along this journey with us.

Abdullah Masoodi: My biggest thank you goes to everyone who's here today. The people here for me, but the people here for everyone else who's standing here. Because without your support, I don't think any of us can continue to do what we're doing for a week and a half. Again, every single individual standing on this table sees ways or deficits we have in the student union or in the university, and ways we can help to best support the students of this university. We all run in to be your voice, not just me. So again, I really do appreciate you your guys being here and I really, you know, thank you guys for also giving me this opportunity. To be here as well.

Host: Thank you, Erin.

Erin: Thank you so much, everyone, for showing up. It's so great, even though the lights are bright, to see that there's so many faces in the audience, so many people who care about student voice and the next leader of the McMaster student union. And I'm so grateful as well, to be here with, like, so such a great group of people. All of these people are incredibly kind, and I know that, you know, regardless who ends up the next MSU president, you guys are going to have someone who cares for you and someone who wants to create a better msu.

Emily Donjong: Marianne, I am very grateful for the chance that I've had to run in this election. It's been a very enriching and unique experience. And honestly, also to have see right now so many people engaged in something like this. It's also very incredible to see. I've had so much fun and such a fulfilling perspective change by boothing and tabling and muscle and speaking to so many people. There's something that resonates with me and every single one of these people's platforms, and I hope that there is at least one thing in everyone's platform that resonates with you as well.

Host: Colin.

Colin Scott: Thank you, everyone, for showing up today. It's been great meeting, meeting all of you for the past two weeks. And every candidate here, I think, has an amazing vision for McMaster. And regardless of the outcome, I'll be here. I'll be fighting for you. So thank you for showing up.

Host: And lastly, Christopher.

Christopher Xenos: Yeah. So my decision to run for president as a first year was less about winning or vengeance against the msu, you for my tape violations, and more about learning about the school and having the opportunity to meet a lot of new people. And I've done exactly that. And I've better informed my future of this, better informed my opinion of the school for the future. And if I don't win this year, I will be back.

Host: And there you have it, ladies and gentlemen, that concludes the all candidates debate. To all those watching remotely, thank you for tuning in. To those who attended in person, thank you for taking the time to stay and attend the debate. A huge thank you to the elections department for their support in organizing the debate and the candidates for taking the time to speak to students. Polling for the election is now open, so check your email and click the link to vote. Reminder to everyone that the MSU is doing a giveaway. Every student who votes will have a chance of winning. A 24 inch TV, an air fryer, AirPods, and so many other cool prizes. Thank you so much. And get home safe.